Travel Agents: Taiwan — Rules Draft (first-pass outline)

> A skeleton for `bg-developer / bg-elegance` to flesh into the real rulebook. Teach-in-play order. Voice: warm mission-dossier / over-caffeinated tour-guide (per identity.md). Keep it tight — `complexity-budget.json` caps the rulebook at 1100 words. Detail lives in `design-doc.md` .

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0. The pitch (read aloud, 20 seconds)

"You're a food-obsessed travel agent on a top-secret snack mission across Taiwan. Ride the rails, source real ingredients from the regions that actually grow them, and plate the island's greatest dishes into your Traveller's Log. You've got a secret Assignment — but sometimes the smart move is to tip off a rival, because a good deed banks you a favour and pushes the whole table's Grand Tour forward. Best trip wins."

1. Goal

Score the most points from plated dishes, your secret Assignment, and the shared Grand Dossier bonuses everyone earns together. Highest Traveller's Log wins.

2. Setup (teach while you set up)

1. Unfold the Taiwan map — four regions in a ring: North 北 · Central 中 · South 南 · East 東 (the HSR line links North–Central–South down the west coast). Put the Grand Dossier marker at 0 and the score markers at 0.
2. Stock the ingredient supply: each region's two specialties by that region, plus the pantry pile (the convenience store — available anywhere). Put the Insider Tip tokens nearby.
3. Shuffle the Dish deck; deal a Menu of 4 face-up (5 at 3p, 6 at 4p).
4. Each agent: take a pawn (start on opposite regions at 2p — one North, one South), draw 2 Assignments, keep 1 secret, return the other. Your Larder starts empty and stays face-up in the open — the Assignment is the only thing you keep hidden.

3. How a turn works (the core loop — teach these five, then just play)

Your Larder (the ingredients you're carrying) sits face-up in the open in front of you all game — there's no hidden hand; the only secret in the game is your Assignment. On your turn, do ONE action. Then if your Larder is over 7 ingredients, discard down to 7.

- STOCK UP — take 2 ingredients where you stand (this region's specialties and/or pantry).
- TRAVEL — move to a neighbouring region, then take 1 ingredient there. (North↔South is a neighbour by HSR.)

- PLATE — pick a Menu dish you can pay for, spend its recipe from your Larder, and lay the Dish card in your Traveller's Log. Refill the Menu. Advance the Grand Dossier +1.
- DEAD-DROP (the tip-off) — hand 1 ingredient to a rival ("you have to try this"). Score +1 VP, take 1 Insider Tip for yourself, and advance the Grand Dossier +1. (3–4p: a player can receive only one Dead-drop per round.)
- EXTRACT — belly full, wallet empty, you sprint to catch the last HSR home before it pulls out of the station: declare your trip done and trigger the end-game (see §6). (The one "spy" word that sounds dramatic — it's really just "I'm stuffed, let's go home.")

> Insider Tips (spend anytime, free): pick one — take 1 extra ingredient here · treat 1 recipe ingredient as any type when plating · travel 1 extra region.

4. Sourcing & recipes (the "aha": travel because the food lives there)

- You can only take a region's specialty while you're in that region — oysters in the South, tea in the Central hills, rice & mountain greens in the East, beef & pork in the North.
- Pantry supplies are at the convenience store in every region.
- A Dish is a little recipe of 2–3 named ingredients. To plate the Chishang bento you need East rice and Northern pork — so you travel. (That's the whole game in one sentence.)

5. The Grand Dossier (the shared beat)

Every Plate and every Dead-drop nudges the shared marker +1. When it crosses a milestone, every player scores that Discovery bonus (a rising tide — we did the tour together!), and the player who pushed it over picks a small reward: an Insider Tip or +1 VP. The final milestone can end the game (§6).

(Milestones at 4/8/12/16 for 2p; scale up at higher counts — see design-doc.)

6. Ending the trip

The end-game begins the moment either: a player takes EXTRACT (catches the last HSR home), or the Grand Dossier hits its final milestone. Then: finish the current round, play one more full round, and stop.

7. Scoring (reveal Assignments now!)

Add up your Traveller's Log: 1. Dishes — 3 VP (2-ingredient) · 4 VP (3-ingredient) · 5 VP (Signature). 2. Assignment — +7 if you pulled it off (flip it face-up), else 0. 3. Dead-drops — +1 VP for each Dead-drop you made (that's why sharing pays). 4. Grand Dossier — the flat Discovery bonuses you banked along the way, plus any +1 VP you took as a triggerer's pick (Insider Tips are leverage — they're worth 0 VP now). Most points wins. Ties: most dishes, then most regions visited.

8. The warm-tone reminders (margin asides, not rules)

- Dead-drops are recommendations, not thefts — you're a fan sharing the good stuff.
- Dish names stay real (romanised + 繁體). The comedy is the mission gag and your own gluttony — never the food or the place.

Teaching sequence (FTUE — the order a first game should reveal rules)

1. Goal + one dish — "here's beef noodle; it needs beef (North) + a pantry staple. Let's get it."
2. Stock Up / Travel — source the two ingredients; feel the "travel because the food's there" turn.
3. Plate — score it, nudge the Grand Dossier; point at the shared bonus track.
4. Assignment — "here's your secret mission; it shapes which dishes you chase."
5. Dead-drop — first time someone's Larder is full: "rather than discard, tip a rival — you get an Insider Tip and push the tour." (This is the teachable moment for the co-op layer.)
6. Extract / end-game — introduce once the Dossier is ~half full.

Still to specify (→ `bg-developer`)

- Exact Dish deck (24 cards) + Assignment deck (14–16) as component data (CSV).
- Final ingredient supply counts; Insider Tip token count.
- Player-aid card (≤16 lines) — the five actions + Insider Tip uses + end-trigger.
- Iconography for 9 ingredients + 4 regions (dual-coded colour and emblem — `bg-access`).